

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: Polish

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

Standard Polish. Nasal vowels ą/ę are shown broadly; their exact surface realization is context-dependent.

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Oral vowels	/a ɛ i ɨ ɔ u/
Nasal vowels	/ɛ̃ ɔ̃/ with context-dependent realizations
Stress	Usually penultimate: Warszawa /var'sava/

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p b t d k g/
Fricatives	/f v s z ɕ ʑ ʃ ʒ x/
Affricates	/t͡s d͡z t͡ɕ d͡ʑ t͡ʂ d͡ʐ/
Nasals	/m n ɲ/
Liquids / glides	/l r j w/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
A a	/a/	mama /'mama/	
Ą ą	/ɔ̃/	wąż /vɔ̃ʂ/	Context-dependent nasal vowel.
B b	/b/	but /but/	Final b devoices to [p].
C c	/t͡s/	co /t͡sɔ/	
Ć ć	/t͡ɕ/	ćma /t͡ɕma/	
D d	/d/	dom /dɔm/	Final d devoices to [t].
E e	/ɛ/	ekran /'ɛkran/	
Ę ę	/ɛ̃/	język /'jɛ̃ʒik/	Often loses nasality word-finally.
F f	/f/	fakt /fakt/	
G g	/g/	góra /'gura/	
H h	/x/	herbata /xɛr'bata/	Same sound as ch.
Ch ch	/x/	chata /'xata/	
I i	/i/; palatalization marker	igła /'igwa/	After consonants, i often palatalizes.
J j	/j/	jak /jak/	
K k	/k/	kot /kɔt/	
L l	/l/	las /las/	
Ł ł	/w/	łódź /wuɫɕ/	Not an English l sound.
M m	/m/	mama /'mama/	
N n	/n/	noc /nɔt͡s/	
Ń ń	/ɲ/	koń /kɔɲ/	
O o	/ɔ/	oko /'ɔkɔ/	
Ó ó	/u/	góra /'gura/	Same sound as u.
P p	/p/	pan /pan/	
R r	/r/	rok /rɔk/	Trilled/tapped rhotic.
S s	/s/	sok /sɔk/	
Ś ś	/ɕ/	świat /ɕfjat/	
T t	/t/	tak /tak/	
U u	/u/	ucho /'uxɔ/	Same sound as ó.
W w	/v/	woda /'vɔda/	Final w devoices to [f].
Y y	/i/	ryba /'rɪba/	
Z z	/z/	zupa /'zupa/	
Ż ż	/ʐ/	źle /ʐlɛ/	
Ź ź	/z/	żaba /'ʐaba/	Same sound as rz.
Rz rz	/z/	rzeka /'ʐɛka/	May devoice to [ʂ] after voiceless consonants.
Cz cz	/t͡ʂ/	czas /t͡ʂas/	

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
Dz dz	/d͡z/	dzwon /d͡zvɔn/	
Dź/dzi	/d͡ʑ/	dzień /d͡ʑɛɲ/	
Dż dż	/d͡ʒ/	dżem /d͡ʒɛm/	
Sz sz	/ɕ/	szkoła /'ɕkɔwa/	

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Stress	Stress is usually on the penultimate syllable, but loanwords and some verb forms can differ.
Nasal vowels	ą/ę change by context: before p/b they can sound like [ɔm]/[ɛm], before t/d like [ɔn]/[ɛn], etc.
Final devoicing	Voiced obstruents devoice word-finally: chleb [xlɐp].
Two sibilant series	Polish contrasts hard postalveolars /ɕ ʑ ʒ d͡ʑ/ with soft alveolo-palatals /ç ʝ ʒ̥ d͡ʑ̥/.